# A Collection of Childhood Memories

## With Poems by Theodore Roethke, May Swenson, Robert Fitzgerald, Robert Frost and Galway Kinnell

### My Papa's Waltz by Theodore Roethke (Pg 18)

The whiskey on your breath

Could make a small boy dizzy;

But I hung on like death:

Such waltzing was not easy.

We romped until the pans

Slid from the kitchen shelf;

My mother's countenance

Could not unfrown itself.

The hand that held my wrist

Was battered on one knuckle;

At every step you missed

My right ear scraped a buckle.

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You beat time on my head

With a palm caked hard by dirt,

Then waltzed me off to bed

Still clinging to your shirt.

## INTRODUCTION

*Childhood was a time when the world felt endless, and every corner held a new adventure. You see, kids have a unique way of seeing the world -- like turning a stick into a horse or imagining bending trees as part of a game instead of signs of bad weather. Childhood is a precious chapter in life that shapes our sense of wonder, joy, and connection. It's a time when the world feels full of possibilities, and every day is an adventure waiting to unfold. These early experiences shape how we see the world and who we become. And as we grow older, childhood memories remind us of the joy and wonder we once felt. My wish for all of us is that we can always hold on to that sense of magic. . .*

*A Collection of Childhood Memories with poems by Theodore Roethke, May Swenson, Robert Fitzgerald, Robert Frost and Galway Kinnell*

### The Centaur by May Swenson (Pg 19-21)

The summer that I was ten–

Can it be there was only one

summer that I was ten? It must

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have been a long one then–
each day I'd go out to choose
a fresh horse from my stable

which was a willow grove
down by the old canal.
I'd go on my two bare feet.

But when, with my brother's jack-knife,
I had cut me a long limber horse
with a good thick knob for a head,

and peeled him slick and clean
except a few leaves for the tail,
and cinched my brother's belt

around his head for a rein,
I'd straddle and canter him fast
up the grass bank to the path,

trot along in the lovely dust
that talcumed over his hoofs,
hiding my toes, and turning

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his feet to swift half-moons.
The willow knob with the strap
jouncing between my thighs

was the pommel and yet the poll
of my nickering pony's head.
My head and my neck were mine,

yet they were shaped like a horse.
My hair flopped to the side
like the mane of a horse in the wind.

My forelock swung in my eyes,
my neck arched and I snorted.
I shied and skittered and reared,

stopped and raised my knees,
pawed at the ground and quivered.
My teeth bared as we wheeled

and swished through the dust again.
I was the horse and the rider,
and the leather I slapped to his rump

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spanked my own behind.
Doubled, my two hoofs beat
a gallop along the bank,

the wind twanged in my mane,
my mouth squared to the bit.
And yet I sat on my steed

quiet, negligent riding,
my toes standing the stirrups,
my thighs hugging his ribs.

At a walk we drew up to the porch.
I tethered him to a paling.
Dismounting, I smoothed my skirt

and entered the dusky hall.
My feet on the clean linoleum
left ghostly toes in the hall.

**Cobb Would Have Caught It by Robert Fitzgerald (Pg 37)**

In sunburnt parks where Sundays lie,
Or the wide wastes beyond the cities,
Teams in grey deploy through sunlight.

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Talk it up, boys, a little practice.

Coming in stubby and fast, the baseman
Gathers a grounder in fat green grass,
Picks it stinging and clipped as wit
Into the leather: a swinging step
Wings it deadeye down to first.
Smack. Oh, attaboy, attaoldboy.

Catcher reverses his cap, pulls down
Sweaty casque, and squats in the dust:
Pitcher rubs new ball on his pants,
Chewing, puts a jet behind him;
Nods past batter, taking his time.
Batter settles, tugs at his cap:
A spinning ball: step and swing to it,
Caught like a cheek before it ducks
By shivery hickory: socko, baby:
Cleats dig into dust. Outfielder,
On his way, looking over shoulder,
Makes it a triple. A long peg home.

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Innings and afternoons. Fly lost in sunset.

Throwing arm gone bad. There's your old ball game.

Cool reek of the field. Reek of companions.

**Birches by Robert Frost (Pg 92-93)**

When I see birches bend to left and right

Across the lines of straighter darker trees,

I like to think some boy's been swinging them.

But swinging doesn't bend them down to stay

As ice-storms do. Often you must have seen them

Loaded with ice a sunny winter morning

After a rain. They click upon themselves

As the breeze rises, and turn many-colored

As the stir cracks and crazes their enamel.

Soon the sun's warmth makes them shed crystal shells

Shattering and avalanching on the snow-crust—

Such heaps of broken glass to sweep away

You'd think the inner dome of heaven had fallen.

They are dragged to the withered bracken by the load,

And they seem not to break; though once they are bowed

So low for long, they never right themselves:

You may see their trunks arching in the woods

Years afterwards, trailing their leaves on the ground

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Like girls on hands and knees that throw their hair

Before them over their heads to dry in the sun.

But I was going to say when Truth broke in

With all her matter-of-fact about the ice-storm

I should prefer to have some boy bend them

As he went out and in to fetch the cows—

Some boy too far from town to learn baseball,

Whose only play was what he found himself,

Summer or winter, and could play alone.

One by one he subdued his father's trees

By riding them down over and over again

Until he took the stiffness out of them,

And not one but hung limp, not one was left

For him to conquer. He learned all there was

To learn about not launching out too soon

And so not carrying the tree away

Clear to the ground. He always kept his poise

To the top branches, climbing carefully

With the same pains you use to fill a cup

Up to the brim, and even above the brim.

Then he flung outward, feet first, with a swish,

Kicking his way down through the air to the ground.

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So was I once myself a swinger of birches.

And so I dream of going back to be.

**First Song by Galway Kinnell (Pg 123)**

Then it was dusk in Illinois, the small boy

After an afternoon of carting dung

Hung on the rail fence, a sapped thing

Weary to crying. Dark was growing tall

And he began to hear the pond frogs all

Calling on his ear with what seemed their joy.

Soon their sound was pleasant for the boy

Listening in the smoky dusk and the nightfall

Of Illinois, and from the fields two small

Boys came bearing cornstalk violins

And they rubbed the cornstalk bows with resins

And the three sat there scraping of their joy.

It was now fine music the frogs and the boys

Did in the towering Illinois twilight make

And into dark in spite of a shoulder's ache

A boy's hunched body loved out of a stalk

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The first song of his happiness, and the song woke

His heart to the darkness and into the sadness of joy.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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